Munde. Pankaja had expected that the BJP would nonetheless accommodate her as an MLC or induct her sister into the Union council of ministers. Far from that, the party elevated former Aurangabad mayor Dr Bhagwat Karad as a Rajya Sabha MP and later as the Union minister of state for finance. And Ramesh Karad from Latur was picked to be an MLC. Since those two are also from the Vanjari caste, it was a clear cold shoulder to the Munde sisters. There have been other signs of rupture too. In January, the BJP left Pankaja out of its list of invitees for a public meeting addressed by party president J.P. Nadda in Aurangabad (though she did attend it eventually). And in April, GST officials raided the Vaidyanath sugar factory in Parli, which the Mundes control, for alleged tax evasion.

Eknath Khadse, an old-time associate of Gopinath Munde and now NCP leader, rues how the BJP is ignoring the family of the late politician, who had driven the BJP's expansion among the 'Bahujan samaj' (non-Brahmin masses) in Maharashtra in the 1980s and was one of the tallest leaders in the state. In addition to the Vanjaris in Marathwada, Vidarbha and western Maharashtra, Munde's support base comprised other communities like the Malis and Dhangars, and even a section of elite castes like the Marathas and Brahmins. Pankaja's supporters had thus expected that after her father's death, she would be appointed as chief minister when the BJP came to power in Maharashtra in 2014. However, that mantle went to Devendra Fadnavis, a Brahmin. At that point, Pankaja had emphatically remarked that she was the "CM in the hearts of the people".

Today, political watchers in the state have differing opinions. A few close to Pankaja—a case in point being Prakash Mahajan, the younger brother of Pramod Mahajan and Pankaja's maternal uncle—feel a mass leader is being "cornered" and that the people being propped up to replace her have no mass base among the Vanjaris. Many others, though, believe it's time Pankaja came to terms with her 2019 defeat.

Even those unwilling to write her off are divided on her future. Some say the Munde sisters still wield some bargaining power within the BJP on account of their Vanjari vote base, especially in Marathwada. Others believe, for the same reason, in her capacity to do something more dramatic: chart her own course. Pankaja's petulant posturing goaded leaders from the Congress, Uddhav Thackeray's Shiv Sena and, curiously, even the Eknath Shinde-led Sena to say they'd be happy to welcome her to their respective parties. NCP's Khadse and Pankaja too held a closed-door meeting on Munde's death anniversary.

Before Pankaja's recent statements, there were already signs of a thaw between her and Dhananjay. In December last year, the two had ensured that the elections to the Nathra gram panchayat, where the Mundes hail from, took place unopposed. Reportedly, Pankaja may also contest the next assembly polls from Pathardi in Ahmednagar instead of Parli to avoid friction. Given such shifting weather patterns, there's no predicting which way the Munde ship will sail. ■

THINGS TURNED SOUR BETWEEN PANKAJA MUNDE AND THE BJP AFTER HER SHOCK DEFEAT IN THE 2019 STATE POLLS TO NCP'S DHANANJAY MUNDE



By Rahul Noronha

The poll season has set in over Madhya Pradesh, and it comes bearing pretty presents by parties in the fray looking to woo voters. The latest handouts by Chief Minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan contain the usual complement—free pilgrimage travel for senior citizens, interest waivers for farmers, cash assistance of Rs 1,000-3,000 to women et al. Among them is that gift that keeps on giving, election after election: the regularisation of unauthorised colonies. Thousands of these across the state are set to benefit from his promises. It's a long list: infrastructure, water, electricity, other facilities. "Development fees will not be charged from poor residents," Chouhan said on May 23 as he announced his general amnesty for all colonies built without proper clearances in the state until December 31, 2022. This includes 6,077 colonies identified till December 31, 2016, and nearly 2,500 will be added to the list per the December 2022 deadline. The government aims to finish the process by June 30.